

RECEIVING HIS LOVE

We love because
he first loved us.
1 John 4:19



Pink Rose

WEEK THREE

RECEIVING HIS LOVE

Opening Prayer

God of Love,

Open my heart to receive You.

Let Your love spill into every corner of my being.

Fill me with Your Spirit, so that my cup runneth
over.

Teach me to rest in Your peace
and receive the love You freely give.

Amen.

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he first loved us.
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Song for Reflection:
Clair de Lune - Debussy



OUR GUIDE

St. Elizabeth of the Trinity

Laudem Gloriae



"Let yourself be loved."

- St. Elizabeth of the Trinity

THEIR STORY

- ✦ **Born:** 1880 in Bourges, France. Her father died in battle when she was just seven years old. From that early grief, she turned toward God as her truest Father — the one who would never leave.
- ✦ **Character:** Elizabeth was fiery and passionate by nature — not the serene, quiet girl one might imagine in a Carmelite. She struggled with her temperament as a young woman, but she poured that intensity into prayer and learned to let God transform what she could not tame.
- ✦ **Called:** She entered the Carmel of Dijon at 21, taking her religious name joyfully. Within the cloister, she didn't find confinement — she found freedom. The freedom to simply be loved, without performance, without proving.
- ✦ **Philosophy:** Captivated by Ephesians 1:12 — "to the praise of His glory" — she coined her own spiritual name: *Laudem Gloriae* (Praise of Glory). She believed holiness was not something we achieve. It is something we receive and radiate.
- ✦ **Music as Metaphor:** Elizabeth described the soul as an instrument through which God plays His love. Her prayer was not striving but tuning — surrendering herself to His presence so that He could make music through her.
- ✦ **Legacy:** She died at 26 from Addison's disease, leaving behind a treasury of letters and her famous prayer, "O My God, Trinity Whom I Adore" — not a prayer for more virtue, but simply to be still and let Love have its way.

THE HEART OF YOUR SONG

Why the Music Exists at All

Before a composer sets a single note to paper, something moves in them. A longing. An impulse. A love that simply must become sound.

That is where you begin.

Not with your colors or your personality type or your strengths — as beautiful as all of those are. You begin with the reason you exist at all: God loved you into being. Not because He needed to. Not because you earned it. But because love, by its very nature, creates.

And you are what His love created.

This is the heart of your song.

Not a quality you possess, not a virtue you practice — the origin point. The reason the music exists.

Everything we discover together in the weeks ahead — every beautiful and unique thing about how He made you — flows from this single, inexhaustible source. So before we go any further, we pause here. We settle into this truth. We let it do what it needs to do.

We love because He first loved us.

AN OVERVIEW

The Primacy of Love

- **God is Love:** Scripture tells us plainly — God is love. To know love is to know God. To know God is to know love. They are not separate things.
- **Love as the Overarching Theme:** From Genesis to Revelation, the common thread of all salvation history is this: God's love for us, and His longing for us to love Him in return. Everything flows from and returns to this.
- **Everything is a Gift of Love:** Our lives, our selves, our families — our blessings and even our pains — are given out of love, ordered to one end: to draw us closer to the Father, Son, and Spirit who want to live with us in love for all eternity.
- **The Greatest Commandments:** In Matthew 22:37-39, Jesus names what is first and most essential: love God with everything you have. Then love your neighbor as yourself. These two commandments hold everything else together.
- **The Necessity of Proper Self-Love:** The phrase "as yourself" carries weight. Before we can rightly love others, we must receive and reflect a proper love of self — not pride, but a humble acknowledgment that we, too, are made in His image.
- **We Cannot Give What We Don't Have:** The love we extend to others must come from somewhere. It comes from God. We receive His love first — and only then do we have something real to give.
- **The Eyes of Love:** When we place God first and receive His love humbly, we begin to see clearly — ourselves and others — as He sees us: fearfully and wonderfully made, worthy of love, created to love and be loved.

GOD IS LOVE

The Thread Running Through All Things

Love and the Nature of God

- God does not merely have love — He is love. 1 John 4:16 is not a metaphor; it is a declaration of His very nature.
- This means that every encounter with love — however small, however human — is in some way an encounter with God Himself.
- To grow in love is to grow in God. To receive love is to receive Him.

The Story Love Wrote

- From the first word of creation to the last breath of Christ on the cross, every page of salvation history is a love story.
- God did not need to create us. He was complete in Himself. He created us because love, by its nature, desires to give.
- Every gift of grace — the law, the prophets, the Incarnation, the Eucharist — is love finding another way to reach us.

Everything as Gift

- Nothing in your life arrived by accident. Your blessings are love. Your sufferings are love. Your very existence is love.
- This is not a comfortable truth — it is a transforming one. When we begin to see all things through the lens of love, the story of our lives changes.
- Even the hard things become a question: How is He loving me here?

LOVE YOUR NEIGHBOR AS YOURSELF

Receiving First, Giving Second

The "As Yourself" Distinction

- Jesus does not say love your neighbor instead of yourself, or more than yourself. He says as yourself.
- This small phrase carries enormous weight. It assumes a right relationship with oneself — not pride, but a humble, clear-eyed acceptance of one's own belovedness.
- We cannot pour from an empty cup. We cannot give what we do not have.

Receiving Before Giving

- The order matters. First, we receive God's love — into our own hearts, into our own emptiness. Only then do we have something real to extend.
- Love that flows outward must flow from somewhere. This is not selfishness. It is the proper order of love.
- Think of Mary at the feet of Jesus — receiving first — before she became what she was to the Church and to the world.

The Eyes of Love

- When we place God first and receive His love humbly, we begin to see clearly — ourselves and others — as He sees us.
- We are fearfully and wonderfully made. Worthy of love. Not because of what we have done, but because of who made us.
- And we begin to extend that same vision outward — to our brothers and sisters in Christ, made in that same image, equally beloved, equally worthy.
- This is the vision love gives us. And it changes everything.

KNOW THYSELF

The Cup of My Heart

*Our hearts are like cups — sometimes cracked,
sometimes turned upside down.*

*Tonight, ask God to heal those cracks and help you
turn your heart upright again: open, ready to receive
His love.*

*Take a quiet moment and pray:
“Lord, how open is my heart to Your love?”*

Listen for what He reveals.

*What keeps you from receiving love — guilt, fear,
control, busyness?
Where do you sense Him trying to pour love in?*



*Imagine God filling your heart to the very brim, so
much that his love spills over the top.*

*Whisper aloud:
“Jesus, I open my heart to receive Your love.”*

*Rest in the stillness. Let His love fill every empty space.
If you'd like, write or share what helps you feel most
loved — by God or by others.*

*Let your heart stay open.
Love continues to pour, even in silence.*

KNOW THYSELF, CONTINUED

Reflection Questions

Take a few quiet moments to write what God is revealing to you this week.

When I prayed "Lord, how open is my heart to Your love?" — what did He show me?

When I imagined His love filling my heart to the brim — what word, image, or feeling came?

What is one thing keeping me from receiving His love fully right now — guilt, fear, busyness, control? Where do I sense Him trying to pour love in?

Is there one person in my life I find it hard to love well right now? Could it be that my own cup needs filling first?

BRING IT TO GOD

The One who loves you is not distant. He is here. Bring what stirred in you tonight directly to Him.

Read back through the Cup of My Heart activity. What is the one thing that surfaced most — the crack, the wall, the place He was trying to reach? Bring it to Him now. You don't need the right words.

Sit with this: He was loving you before you knew how to receive it. Before you knew you needed it. He has never stopped. Tell Him what that stirs in you.

Ask Him: *"Lord, what do You want me to know about how You love me — not in general, but right now, today, as I actually am?"*
Then wait. Write what comes.

BRING IT TO GOD, CONTINUED

Is there a part of you that finds it hard to believe His love is really for you — not just for others, not just in theory? Bring that resistance to Him honestly. He can hold it.

Close by receiving. Simply say — aloud if you can:

"I receive Your love. Not because I have earned it. Not because I am ready. But because You give it freely, and I am learning to open my hands."

Then rest. Let Him love you.

*We love because
he first loved us.
1 John 4:19*

LIVING IT OUT

Take what God spoke to you tonight and carry it into your week.

Receive: Each morning this week, before you do anything else, place your hand on your heart and say aloud:

"I am already loved — fully, freely, and completely — by the One who made me."

Notice what it feels like to say it. Notice if part of you resists. Don't fix it. Just notice.

Reflect: When I think of God's love, do I imagine it as something to earn or something freely given? Where did I learn that?

Discern: What keeps me from letting Him love me as I am, right now — not the version of me that has it together, but the actual, present-tense me?

LIVING IT OUT, CONTINUED

Notice: Watch for the moments this week when you feel most loved — by God, by someone around you, by a kindness you didn't expect. Write them down. They are not accidents. They are His love arriving in the ordinary.

Act: Who in your life might need you to love them from a fuller cup this week? What would that look like in one small, concrete moment?



*"My cup runneth over."
Psalm 23:5*

THIS WEEK

Each day this week, take one moment to pause — even just 30 seconds — and breathe in the truth: “I am loved by God.”

Notice how that truth changes the way you move, speak, or see others.

Let His love fill you first, then gently overflow to those around you.



Closing Prayer

Loving God,

Thank you for pouring Your love into my heart.

Help me to always remember
the love You freely give.

Stay with me, and teach me
to see and believe Your love is eternal.

Keep my heart open to You.

Amen

MY LOVE PORTRAIT

How I Feel God Loving Me:

In one sentence, what this session revealed
about how God made me to be loved:

The barrier I most need to surrender to Him
right now:

A place in my daily life where I sense Him
pouring love in — if I would only slow down
to receive it:

Where is God asking me to open my heart —
not in ideal conditions, but in the actual
conditions of my life right now?

